

sa

WINTER 2023

Homeschooling

and beyond

Make
learning
fun!

How to raise an
entrepreneur

LEARNING
STYLES

Myths and truths

Deciphering
food labels

Enter & win
Drawing
Competition

A parent's
guide

Empowering the child
who learns differently

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Dear Mom and Dad,

Wow this school and learning thing is a lot tougher than I ever thought. I have been asking myself lately.. why is it so tough for me to learn like everyone else?

This question usually makes me quite sad and I can see the same question makes you quite scared. I'm not entirely sure why you feel scared but maybe if I knew I would understand why its the only thing we talk about or the only thing you want to help me with.

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When I am feeling this same pressure I really struggle to calm down and I just want to scream. So I'm wondering is there another way we could learn things?

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Your son, Sazi
(8 yrs and 5 months old)





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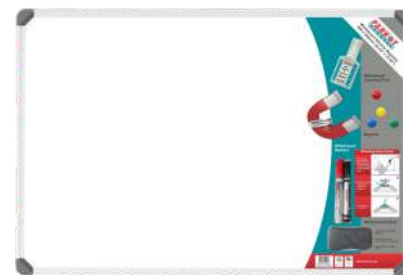


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After a day of running around between meetings, driving our children to their afternoon activities, popping into the shops and preparing supper, I lay in bed with them while our eldest read us a story. Afterwards I briefly left the room and when I returned to give them a goodnight kiss, they were gone. A little baffled at first, I saw feet sticking out from under the

curtain and heard our three-year-old giggling.

It was getting late and already past their bedtime. I was tired and with two deadlines looming, I still had work waiting for me. However, instead of saying my usual "Come on, now, it's time for bed", I decided to play along. Calling their names and even getting my husband to help search for them, I heard the giggling getting louder, until at last we both sprang on them, shouting: "Found you!"

That impromptu frolic taught me a valuable lesson. Parenthood brings many priceless moments of humour and joy to our lives. But too often, the serious and sober realities of adult life, work and raising responsible children overwhelm our spontaneous, witty and playful sides.

Laughing out loud and having fun with our kids is good for our souls – and theirs.

When something funny, unexpected or special happens, capture it on video, in a photograph or in a journal and relive that memory when you're feeling frustrated, down or simply in need of cheering up. Those are the moments when love comes out to play – and claim us for its own.

Happy reading!

Adri



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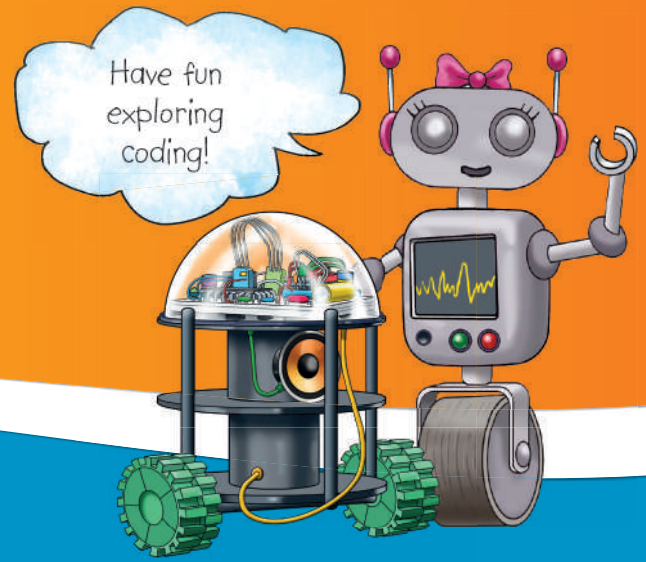
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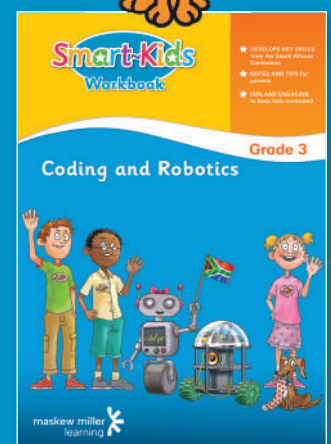
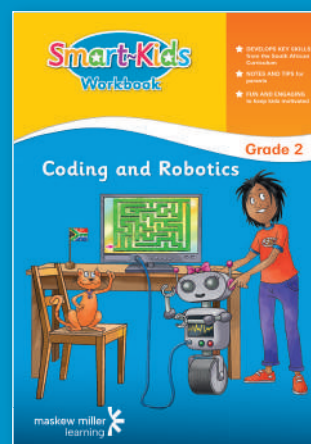
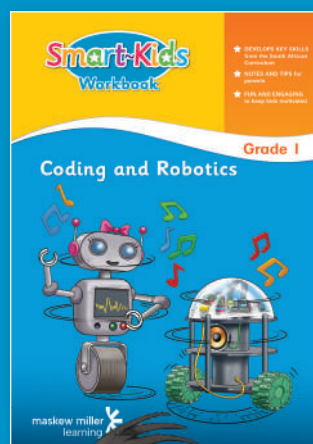
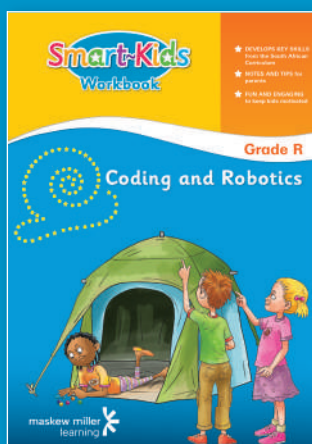
Meet Robo and Spinner!

Robo and Spinner are the new Smart-Kids characters who will help teach children the basic principles of coding and robotics.

Aligned to the draft coding and robotics curriculum released by the Department of Basic Education, the Smart-Kids Coding & Robotics workbooks consist of write-in worksheets that can be used by teachers to introduce the subject to young learners, or by parents who want their child to learn and practise the skills required for coding and robotics.

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- Grades R,1 and 2 include cutout coding blocks for additional practice.



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Homeschooling strengthens SA's right to education



In recent years, we've seen a major shift towards the acceptance of more alternative forms of education. Louise Schoonwinkel, MD of Optimi Home, South Africa's largest homeschooling and online schooling provider, shares five ways that homeschooling and online schooling can help strengthen the right to education in our country

A key challenge we all face is how we can speed up SA's push to educate its citizens and engender greater equality. This is challenging in an environment where, every year, schools are filled to capacity and provincial education departments have to work extremely hard to find a placement for every child. In these situations, many parents are forced to place their children in schools that aren't their preferred choice, thereby creating additional stress and worry.

One answer to this challenge lies in broadening our country's education reach and taking the strain off our public education system.

We can do this by ensuring that there are more alternative forms of education that can help close the gap, including homeschooling and online schooling.

In recent years, we've started to see a major shift towards the acceptance of more alternative forms of education. This was largely due to the Covid-19 pandemic, which only accelerated this trend. As SA's largest homeschooling and online schooling provider, we experienced a nearly 60% increase in pupil numbers from 2020-2023.

Here are five ways that homeschooling and online schooling can help broaden access to education and

"One answer to this challenge lies in broadening our country's education reach and taking the strain off our public education system."



strengthen the right to education in our country:

1 Quality learning, from anywhere Whether you live on a farm in the Karoo or in an apartment in a big city, homeschooling and online schooling give you the freedom and flexibility to provide your child with an education from anywhere.

You might live in an area where the school choices are limited. Here, homeschooling or online schooling can be a great option.

Using a provider that adheres to quality standards also gives your child flexibility to re-enter a mainstream school at any point.



This may be further beneficial if, for instance, you travel with your children for prolonged periods for work purposes. While travelling, your children can be homeschooled, but if you settle back into one place in SA, you can choose to send your child

to a mainstream school without missing a step.

Another flexible aspect of homeschooling and online schooling is that it's well-suited for children to pursue their talents at a higher level, such as professional athletes, musicians and even entrepreneurs.

2 Pathway to matric Homeschooling and online schooling are different. The former is more self-directed, while the latter has the structure of dedicated teachers and class timetables. However, both of them – especially if accessed via credible and trusted providers such as Impaq – follow the same CAPS-aligned curriculum that every school in the country follows.



SCHOOL

For that reason, these pupils write the same exams as every other schoolchild in the country and receive a National Senior Certificate upon successfully completing matric.

This provides South Africans with another route to matriculation.

3 Choice Homeschooling and online schooling pupils often have access to more subjects than those that are typically offered in schools.



“For you as a parent, online schooling could be the ideal way to blend quality, structured learning and home-based flexibility.”



In a school, pupils at FET level (Grades 10-12) are typically restricted to choosing only a certain number of subjects, depending on the resources available at the school. However, no such limits apply to homeschooling pupils, who can choose to take on extra subjects.

4 Sociability Going the homeschooling or online schooling route doesn't mean that your child will miss out on social activities.

In fact, home-educated children can have more time to engage in several extracurricular activities and interact with a variety of

peers. Children who're part of an online school are also grouped together in a class, where they regularly interact with their peers.

5 Regulation on its way At last, SA's government is working on a framework for online schooling. This is expected to place requirements on online school providers to be registered with the Department of Basic Education. This will engender greater trust and transparency in the space.

For you as a parent, online schooling could be the ideal way to blend quality, structured learning and home-based flexibility. However it's important to select a provider that's fully committed to complying with these requirements, going forward.

Homeschooling and online schooling are expanding our education universe. And by being more open to it, our country stands to benefit in the long term.

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Secrets for adding fun to your homeschool

Homeschooling doesn't have to mean endless workbooks and flashcards. Try one or all of these tips to make your homeschool more fun this year!

Kids who have fun learning are much more likely to love reading and learning and become lifelong students. Here are 10 ideas to bring more fun into your homeschool classroom:

1 Read together at the library As a parent and homeschool teacher, you know how important reading is for your child's growth. However, reading a book at home every day for 30 minutes can become boring. Mix things up by visiting the local library and reading a book together there.



2 Go on a nature walk for exercise Nature walks not only expose your child to nature, where they can learn about flora and fauna, but are great exercise for both of you. You can use a nature walk as their physical education class.

3 Enjoy "breaktime" at a local park Every homeschooling parent and child needs a break throughout the day. Why not let them enjoy their break at a local park?

4 Games Consider games like Trivial Pursuit or Trashketball. You also can make homemade versions of Monopoly or Snakes and Ladders, where game pieces and spots require subject knowledge. Of course, there are also board games designed to teach certain lessons, plus plenty of learning apps with games.

5 Go on field trips Did you know that some zoos and museums offer discounts for homeschoolers or visitors on certain days of the week?

6 Watch documentaries and films together Watching documentaries is a great way for kids to delve deeper into a subject of interest or discover new ones. Watching films is also a fun way to relive a beloved book or series and bond as a family.



7 Incorporate cooking into your homeschool week Food is always a good motivator. Baking can be a good time to see science in action and use maths skills to double a recipe.

8 Volunteer at a local animal shelter Volunteering is a good way to be actively involved in your community, but can also be a great way to chat up the vets about animal biology. In addition, your child will learn to care for and respect animals.



9 Learn another language Actually, learn any foreign language. Walk around your house with a label-maker and write the second language's word for everything.

10 Have a Friday scavenger hunt Homeschooling should be a fun experience for all. Incorporate songs and dancing into the lesson plan for younger children. A scavenger hunt in the house or the yard is a great learning adventure. Give a clue to find an item. That item can be a question related to a lesson that they must answer correctly. If they do, they move on to the next clue. At the end of the hunt, let



them find a small reward, like a chocolate bar or popcorn.

If you've punched a homeschool wall recently, know that there's plenty you can do to change things around. One of the easiest ways to lighten up the mood and make learning enjoyable is to incorporate some fun activities.



Empowering the child who learns differently

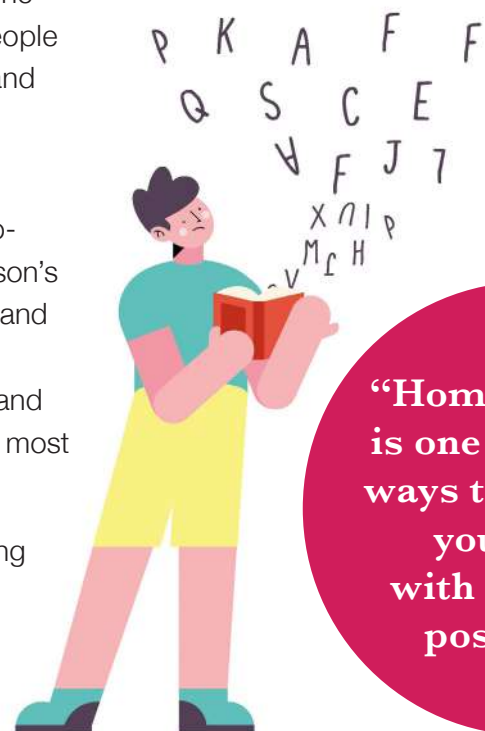
All children need love, encouragement and support, and for kids with learning disabilities, such positive reinforcement can help ensure that they emerge with a strong sense of self-worth, confidence and determination to keep going, even when things are tough



“**L**earning disabilities” or “learning disorders” are umbrella terms for a wide variety of learning problems. A learning disability isn’t a problem of intelligence or motivation and kids with learning disabilities aren’t lazy or dumb. In fact, most are just as smart as everyone else. Their brains are simply wired differently – and this difference affects the way they receive and process information.

Learning disabilities can be very isolating, but they’re also extremely common. The five most common ones in children are:

- 1 **Dyslexia** Dyslexia is the number one learning disability that occurs in people of all ages. It affects a person’s reading and language processing skills.
- 2 **Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD)** ADHD is a neuro-developmental disorder that affects a person’s ability to pay attention, control impulsivity and regulate their level of hyperactivity. It’s the second most common learning disability and can affect people of all ages, although it’s most often diagnosed in children.
- 3 **Dyscalculia** Dyscalculia is a learning disability that affects mathematical skills. People with this disorder battle to understand mathematical concepts and perform arithmetic calculations.





4 Dyspraxia Dyspraxia is a neurological disorder that affects a person's ability to plan and co-ordinate movement. It can affect fine motor skills, such as writing or tying shoelaces, as well as gross motor skills, such as balance and co-ordination.

There are many reasons a child may have difficulties learning. The causes aren't always known, but in many cases they have a parent or relative with the same or similar learning and thinking differences and difficulties. Other risk factors include low birth weight and prematurity, or an injury or illness during childhood (eg a head injury, lead poisoning or a childhood illness like meningitis).

Great job!



Parents can play a significant role in helping a child with a learning disability succeed. Here are seven ways to do so:

- **Create an individualised homeschooling programme.**

The beauty of homeschooling is the ability to create an individualised educational plan for each of your children. You can do this by incorporating strength-based learning, teaching to your child's learning styles and using interest-led learning.

- **Use resources and support groups.** There are many resources and groups to help you learn more about parenting a child with learning difficulties. Learning and thinking differences are common. You and your child aren't alone on this journey.

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of the best
to empower
ur child
the gift of
itivity."



5 Dysgraphia Dysgraphia is a learning disability that affects a person's ability to write. It can manifest as difficulty with spelling, poor handwriting or trouble putting thoughts on paper.



- **Be positive.** Parents need to have an objective and positive view of their children's disability. We all know people who struggled in school, but once they left, soared professionally and personally. Your academic career doesn't define you. This attitude will spill over to children and make them aware that they can identify and develop their talents, and – with persistence and support – realise their dreams.

- **Help children identify an interest or hobby.** Children with learning disabilities need something to do that's pure pleasure – an outlet in which they're immersed in their strengths and interests. It could be drama, art, music, an interest in animals or insects, sports, science or computers. This allows a child to shine in at least one area outside of academics. They can then see themselves as a multi-faceted person, rather than being defined by their difficulties in school.

- **Focus on perseverance and effort.** Children with learning disabilities are often criticised and put down. Parents should



praise them and encourage them to work hard, put in effort and persevere. Studies have shown that children who're praised in this way are motivated to learn and will challenge themselves academically, even if they struggle.

- **Plan for the future.** Help your child plan for adulthood by encouraging them to consider their strengths and interests in education and career choices. Special career and work programmes can help build confidence by teaching decision-making and job skills. Many colleges have programmes to support students who learn and think differently earn a degree.

- **Create a sense of community and celebrate your child's specialness.**

Children with special needs often struggle to fit in. How can you help them feel a sense of community? By doing something as simple as partnering up with a similar parent and child. Start by having



a conversation with your child and brainstorm a few possibilities.

Homeschooling is one of the best ways to empower your child with the gift of positivity. You have the ability to create an environment for your child that's filled with positive words, learning experiences, activities and people.

We hope that you'll take inspiration from these ideas and use them as a springboard for empowering your child to be and feel their best.



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How to raise an entrepreneur



Parents have a crucial role to play in ending the country's growing youth unemployment crisis by encouraging children to become entrepreneurs. Part of this means supporting children who display entrepreneurial behaviour, says Lynn Brown, Special Projects Editor at Africa's premier entrepreneurship initiative The Anzisha Prize

Parents and guardians are often the first influence on a child's entrepreneurial journey. By introducing our children to entrepreneurship at an early age, their experiences – both positive and negative – can help shape their future and could be the start of something amazing.

Presenting ideas and opportunities that are fun and challenging helps young minds that are brimming with

entrepreneurial ideas to become problem-solvers and motivates them to create a positive change in their communities.

Listen to their ideas

It all begins with supporting and nurturing their curiosity. Support children to brainstorm and think of unique solutions to common problems, share them with you and discuss it. Encourage them to be creative and use their imagination. No matter how far-fetched their idea may seem



to you as an adult, providing positive reinforcement and having patience while they figure it out fosters self-confidence and the courage to think outside the box. Parents can be great coaches.

Let them make mistakes

Allow your child to explore and try new things. If they fail, be there to support them and help them learn from their mistakes. While it's sometimes tempting to try to "save the day" – especially if you can identify gaps or downfalls – it's important to let your child follow through and see if their ideas work. Your reaction to their negative experiences will help teach them to see failures as opportunities to learn and do better. Smart risk-taking is a skill that will serve your kids throughout their lives, whether they become entrepreneurs or not. We call this "failing forward".

mistakes
ARE PROOF
that you
ARE TRYING

Leverage your network

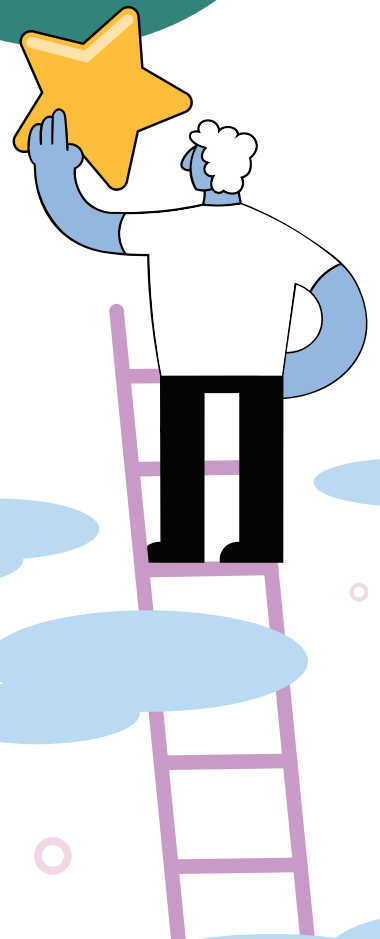
Introducing your kids to entrepreneurial role models in the real world can leave a lasting impression. Allow them to engage with a variety of people from all backgrounds who've chosen to create businesses and jobs, rather than work in them. This offers them opportunities for learning and emulating. Remember that you're their most important entrepreneurial mentor!

We have a responsibility to teach our children how to recognise opportunities, take some risks and learn what it takes to become a future job-creator.

As parents, we want our children to grow up to be happy and successful. Exposing young children or teenagers to the benefits and rewards of entrepreneurship will help them see that there are endless possibilities for their future.



"Exposing young children or teenagers to the benefits and rewards of entrepreneurship will help them see that there are endless possibilities for their future."



Top in-demand careers in SA

Economies worldwide – including South Africa’s – are steadily returning to their old rhythms post-Covid-19. Recovery and growth are creating new opportunities for people seeking to enter the workforce. If your child’s uncertain about what course to study to have a successful in-demand career in SA, read on!

After several challenging years with the pandemic, the world’s finally beginning to bounce back. Online American university Nexford has shared occupations and jobs that will be in demand in the next five years in South Africa, writes Joe McGoldrick.

Software engineer

These professionals are responsible for designing and implementing software solutions. They apply engineering principles in devising software that meets the demands of their clients. They’re also responsible for supervising development, meeting clients and assessing their needs. They implement a systematic approach in a software development life-cycle. LinkedIn agrees that software development and engineering roles are the fastest-growing sectors in SA.

Network administrator

Network administrators are responsible for running and maintaining IT networks. While they do set up networks, the bulk of their work is maintenance. They identify and troubleshoot problems with either software or hardware. They check the system for any vulnerabilities. They also upgrade and replace equipment, when needed. These professionals ensure that IT infrastructure is as efficient and secure as possible.



Data scientist

In today's world, businesses and other organisations are working with huge amounts of data. Data scientists are professionals who deal with these data and process them to create useful information. They use statistics and computer science techniques to organise, clean and analyse data and extract any actionable information.

Health and safety manager

Nowadays, workplace health and safety have become indispensable. Gone are the days when serious bodily harm and even fatalities were regular occurrences. Today we have stricter workplace safety laws in place. Health and safety managers ensure that these laws are fully implemented to make the work environment as safe as possible, particularly in mines, factories and construction sites.

Accountants

Keeping financials in check and well accounted for is essential in any organisation. Every cent spent and earned must



YOU'RE HIRED

be recorded and logged. This is where accountants play a crucial role. They ensure that the company's financial books are in order, right down to the smallest expense. They also help companies comply with the country's many tax laws.

Business consultant

The primary role of a business consultant is to provide solutions for businesses. They propose

strategies and actions to make the company's goals a reality. Their work includes improving business processes, introducing new methods and changing and upgrading obsolete practices.

Lawyer

In a nutshell, lawyers are advocates for their clients. They have their well-being in mind, especially those concerning legal matters. They represent them



in court and other legal forums. They also exercise certain actions for their clients, such as giving legal advice, executing wills and drafting legally sound contracts.

Agricultural engineer

Agriculture plays a huge part in the South African economy – and, like many other sectors, it faces several challenges. Agricultural engineers address these problems by applying engineering principles, as well as other techniques. They tackle things like irrigation, energy and power, the environmental impact of agriculture waste and food storage.

Pilot

These airline professionals are the main reason we have air travel today. They fly and operate aeroplanes, helicopters and other aircraft for personal, commercial or military travel. They perform various specialised roles, from commercial and chartered flights to search-and-rescue missions, wildfire response and other functions.



Nexford also shares courses that are in demand in SA:

1 Information technology (IT)

IT is a discipline that essentially uses both software and hardware to provide solutions. This is an umbrella term that touches on several disciplines such as computer science, computer engineering, information, systems and networking. A degree in IT prepares you to be a multi-disciplinary professional who can specialise in various fields where technology plays a key part.

2 Engineering

Essentially, engineering is the application of maths and science to build, produce or manufacture anything, from buildings, bridges, cities

and cars to new chemicals or technology. A degree in engineering prepares you not only for the specific field you've chosen, but also to think like an engineer. It equips you to apply engineering techniques and concepts to solve various problems.

3 Business administration

A business administration degree prepares you for the challenges of running and operating a business. It takes you through the many aspects of company management, such as marketing, administration and finance. It also teaches you relevant skills to help you succeed in your specialisation.

- Link to original article:
www.nexford.org/insights/top-10-in-demand-careers-in-south-africa

Hospital administrator

While doctors, nurses and other healthcare workers are the heart of the hospital, the hospital administrator ensures that business operations run smoothly. They ensure that health professionals have proper credentials and training, design and enforce hospital policies, and work with local government and other institutions for their programmes.

About the author

Joe McGoldrick

Known for strategy and attention to detail, McGoldrick has more than 10 years' marketing experience working within the public sector, client-side and agency-side. He's passionate about using data and customer insights to improve marketing performance.



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Winter soups to keep your family cosy

These easy-to-make, hearty soups will keep you and your family warm on a cold winter's day

Warm up even the chilliest weather with biltong soup, broccoli soup or chicken-corn chowder from chef and mom of four Anri Fourie.

Biltong soup

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 20 mins

Ingredients:

125ml (½ cup) butter

2 beef stock cubes

10ml (2 tsp) ground black pepper

2ml (½ tsp) ground nutmeg

2ml (½ tsp) ground coriander

250ml (1 cup) cake flour

500ml (2 cups) milk

1,5L (6 cups) boiling water

250ml (1 cup) grated cheese

300g biltong powder

100g thinly sliced biltong (for garnishing)





What else you will need:

- A chopping board
- A knife
- A medium-sized pot
- A wooden spoon

Method:

- Melt the butter in the medium-sized pot.
- Add the 2 beef stock cubes, pepper, nutmeg, coriander and cake flour to the melted butter.
- Stir over a medium heat until it starts to boil.
- Mix the milk and water together.
- Add the milk mixture to the pot and stir well until it thickens.
- Remove the pot from the stove and add the biltong and cheese. Do not reboil.
- Pour into soup bowls and garnish with thinly cut biltong.



Broccoli soup

Preparation time: 10 mins

Cooking time: 20 mins

Ingredients:

- 1 packet diced/minced bacon (leave out for vegetarian option)
- 62ml (¼ cup) butter
- 1 onion, chopped



- 1L (4 cups) chicken stock
- 2 broccoli heads
- 2 large potatoes, peeled and diced
- 500ml (2 cups) milk
- 250ml (1 cup) grated cheese
- 2 feta cheese wheels
- Salt and pepper to taste

What else you will need:

- A chopping board
- A knife
- A medium-sized pot
- A wooden spoon
- A stick blender

Method:

- Melt the butter in the medium-sized pot.
- Add the onion and bacon. Fry until bacon is crispy.
- Add the broccoli, potatoes and chicken stock, cover and simmer for 15 mins.
- Blend the broccoli mixture with the stick blender until smooth.
- Remove from the heat and stir in the grated cheese.
- Add salt and pepper to taste.
- Top with crumbled feta cheese.



Chicken-corn chowder

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 45 mins

Ingredients:

- 1 packet diced/minced bacon
- Oil for frying
- 4 skinless, deboned chicken breasts, cut into 2cm cubes
- 1 red pepper, diced
- 5ml (1 tsp) garlic
- 1 onion, diced
- 1 medium-sized tin corn kernels, drained
- 2 large potatoes, peeled and diced
- 1L (4 cups) chicken stock
- 500ml (2 cups) milk

500ml (2 cups) grated cheese

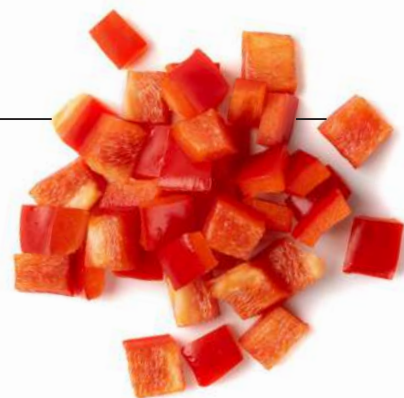
Salt and pepper to taste

What else you will need:

- A chopping board
- A knife
- A large cooking pot
- A small mixing bowl
- A wooden spoon

Method:

- In the large cooking pot, fry the bacon, onion and garlic in a



little oil until the bacon is crispy and the onion is translucent.

- Remove the bacon mixture from the pot and set aside.
- Add the diced chicken and red peppers to the pot and fry in a little oil until the chicken is cooked.
- Add the chicken stock and diced potatoes to the pot and bring to the boil. Lower the heat and cook until the potatoes are tender.
- In a small mixing bowl, add the flour and gradually whisk in the milk.
- Add the milk mixture to the cooking pot.
- Add the corn and cook for 10 minutes.
- Add the bacon mixture to the pot, remove it from the heat and stir in the cheese.
- Season with salt and pepper.



Anri Fourie, owner of two guesthouses and mom of an eight-year-old daughter and four-year-old triplets, cooks meals that are quick and easy to make – with multiple little helping hands. In the Fourie household, family time is a great time to cook together. As the former owner of a coffee shop, Anri used to share the kitchen with skilled chefs. Today she shares it with her four busy little offspring, who're all eager to pitch in and help.



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CHAT TO US!

Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together.

Click [HERE](#) to e-mail our editor





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Ask Dalena



Dalena van der Westhuizen will answer any questions or concerns you may have about learning, concentration, memory and cognitive development – and, of course, the frustrations arising from these

My son was diagnosed with dyslexia earlier this year. He's 13 years old. Does dyslexia affect mathematical skills and memory too and how do dyslexics learn best? – *Madeleine van der Linde*

Hi Madeleine,

The Gibson Institute of Cognitive Research in the USA tested 2 000 struggling readers/dyslexic individuals and found common weak skills that included long- and short-term memory, processing speed and auditory processing. These are all cognitive brain skills that play a role not only in our ability to read and comprehend, but in all other areas of learning as well. As a result, the cognitive weaknesses responsible for reading struggles (such as dyslexia) will impact mathematical skills and memory too.

Here are some tried and tested strategies to help make learning easier for your son:

- Keep instructions simple. Single-step directions that aren't overly complex are easiest for dyslexic students to follow. Always break down complicated instructions into multiple steps for your son to remember and follow.
- Before moving on to a new topic, ensure that he has a firm grasp of what's already been covered. Integrate regular reviews into his study/learning schedule.
- Graphic organisers are great for dyslexic students to use. Knowing what to expect and what to do removes a lot of uncertainty and last-minute stress.
- Speech-to-text software can assist – investigate the numerous options available.
- Remember, time is one of the best gifts you can give a dyslexic student. Make sure your son starts any projects/studying/tasks well in advance.

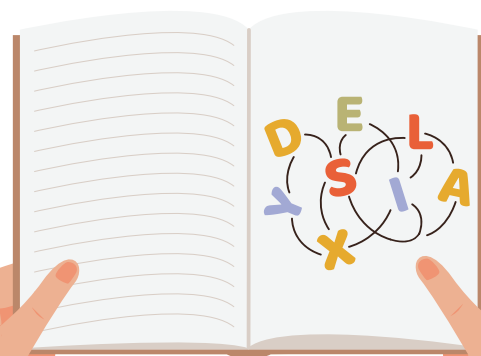
Also teach him how to break down work into smaller chunks, as he could easily feel overwhelmed.

- Memory exercises are always a great help for a dyslexic, so be sure to incorporate these into his daily routine.

What causes lack of motivation in schoolwork and how can I motivate my unmotivated 12-year-old? – Abigail Went

Hi Abigail,

It would be interesting to know whether this has been happening for a while or has it begun recently or suddenly? In my experience, children usually lack motivation when there's a personality clash with a teacher/tutor, when the information isn't presented in an interesting way, when they





struggle to keep up or when they don't grasp the work presented. The first step in helping your child is to pinpoint why they're unmotivated. Start by asking them that question. At the same time, consider digging deeper by means of a professional assessment to help discover other reasons for their lack of motivation. Only then can you begin working on improving it.

My son's in his final school year. His grades are really good. However, he's still uncertain about what to study next year. How can I help him choose the right course? – Brenda Fourie

Hi Brenda,

This is an exciting time in your son's life. Here are my suggestions:

- It's always worthwhile talking to a professional in the field of study choices.
- As a family, make a random list of the possible careers

your son might be interested in – then research which subjects are required for admission to studying in that field, as well as the required mark he'd need in them. If possible, let him talk to someone working in that field or Google it to find more information. Then keep narrowing down the list.

- Make sure you have a "plan B" in case of a shift in your son's interest from one field of study to another between now and when he needs to apply for admission. Two or three alternatives are ideal. Don't narrow down too much into a single field of study and be left with no alternatives/choices.
- Consider letting your son take a gap year to allow him time to investigate various study options.

About Dalena

Dalena van der Westhuizen is the co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, a cognitive development specialist, a master brain coach and an internationally certified cognitive coach. She translates the latest international cognitive research and best practice into strategies that can be applied by parents and educators alike.

A mom and a self-confessed chocoholic, Dalena enjoys working with both kids and adults to improve the way their brains process information for better learning, reading and focusing.



Send your questions for Dalena to: adri@isikhova.co.za.





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Learning liberated

Learners can now experience IGCSE excellence at UCT Online High School. Tessa Venter, Head of School for Cambridge International curriculum, answers questions in relation to IGCSE and its benefits

What are some important factors to consider when choosing an online school?

One of the key considerations that a family should take into account when choosing an online school is the curriculum on offer. Every curriculum offers a learner something different and it's important for families to research where each curriculum can take a learner after school. For the Cambridge International Curriculum, it's critical that families understand that this isn't a curriculum that's exclusively for learners looking



to go overseas. Many learners do their IGCSEs and AS/A levels with the express intention of studying in South Africa and go on to be accepted into top South African universities.

What are some of the advantages of IGCSE at UCT Online High School?

Online schooling really provides a safe, scaffolded space for learners to develop key skills like effective time management, academic independence, responsibility and accountability. These are key skills that Cambridge identifies as a part of their learner attributes. The way in which our IGCSE course is designed encourages and supports learners as they develop these skills.

Further to this, online schooling asks learners to develop practical skills such as navigating online information, using digital platforms to record, write and engage and honing effective communication skills. All of these combine into helping learners develop critical transferable skills that will set them up for success both in tertiary studies and life. Ultimately, this is the value of completing your IGCSEs with UCT Online High School – we've specifically designed our school with the future in mind.

What support is available for learners at UCT Online High School?

Our IGCSE learners have a whole support team behind them who're all focused on equipping them for success. Every learner has a support coach who's ultimately their champion, as well as the

key contact person for guardians or parents. From an academic perspective, our learners engage with highly skilled learning facilitators who have experience in the Cambridge International Curriculum. We also know that school is about more than academics, which is why we take great pride in having a number of virtual clubs on offer, academic support sessions, small social-emotional connections, movement sessions, school assemblies, career guidance and an extra-curricular guide for families.

What resources does UCT Online High School offer?

A huge advantage of doing your IGCSE through us is that

all our course content is included and families don't have to buy textbooks. We want to give as many families as possible the opportunity to study through Cambridge International and know that textbooks are often a large and unbudgeted-for expense. This is why we don't have a specific textbook list for our Cambridge International offering.

We know that our subject content as well as our academic live sessions are detailed, in-depth and designed according to the subject-specific curriculum, as well as taking into account the recommended Cambridge-guided learning hours per subject.



10 classic books every child should read



Simone Billson, homeschool mom, avid reader and classic book enthusiast

Reading gives our kids practice living as heroes, dealing with life-and-death situations, living with virtue and failing at it. As characters struggle through hardship, we struggle with them and we hope to be as brave, bold and fully human as our favourite heroes. Through reading, we get a glimpse of the kind of character we'll become as that story unfolds.

Three benefits of reading and why it should be top of your list for your kids:

1. Increased vocabulary and highly sophisticated language patterns. According to Jim Trelease: "When it comes to prekindergarten skills, vocabulary matters more than anything else. It's the prime predictor of school success or failure."

2. The ability to make connections. Understanding what they read and connecting information they're encountering for the first time to other facts and ideas they've already



encountered, comparing it with stories they've heard before and holding it up against their own lives. Without even intending to, we make connections every time we open the pages of a book.

3. A love for reading. If we want our children to enjoy reading, then we must do more than merely teach our children how to decode text. Through beautiful stories and discussions, we cultivate a deep love of stories.

"Once you learn to read, you will be forever free." – Frederick Douglass

Visit the CC Bookstore for these books and more:

Bookstore Literature

Excellent classic book list as a starting point:

1. *Paddle to the Sea* – C Holling
2. *Charlotte's Web* – EB White
3. *Trumpet of the Swan* – EB White
4. *Adventures With Waffles* – Maria Parr
5. *The Hobbit* – JR Tolkien
6. *Number the Stars* – Lois Lowry
7. *Carry on, Mr Bowditch* – Jean Lee Letham
8. *Laddie* – Gene Stratford Porter
9. *Little Britches* – Ralph Moody
10. *Where the Red Fern Grows* – Wilson Rawls

For more information on books, classic education and the beauty of reading, e-mail: sbillson@classicalconversations.com

Deciphering food labels

A key role for all parents and caregivers is ensuring children have a healthy, nutritious diet to grow and thrive both physically and mentally. Unfortunately, complicated and often misleading labels and marketing techniques make it difficult to discern what's healthy – and what's actually full of added sugar, salt and unhealthy fats

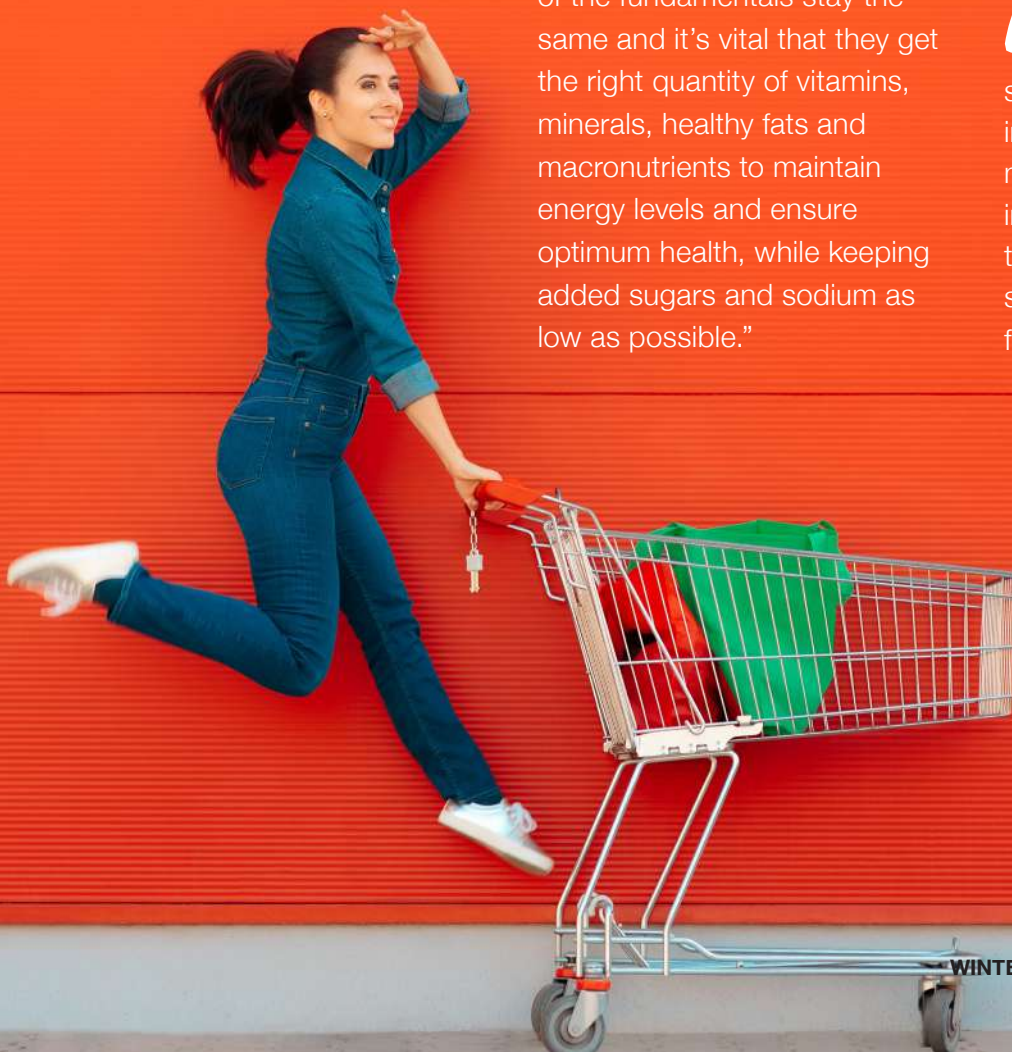
“**T**here's no doubt that the right nutritional balance is a key component of children's growth and development, but it can be difficult for parents and

caregivers to find this balance when they're not always sure what's in the food they're serving,” explains Mbali Mapholi, Laager Tea4Kidz Partner Dietician. “While children's nutritional requirements will change as they grow, many of the fundamentals stay the same and it's vital that they get the right quantity of vitamins, minerals, healthy fats and macronutrients to maintain energy levels and ensure optimum health, while keeping added sugars and sodium as low as possible.”

Mapholi adds that reading nutritional labels and understanding what constitutes a healthy amount of sugar, fats and sodium is key, especially for younger children. Here are her top three tips for reading food labels:

1 Other names for sugars, fats and sodium

Look out for sugar, fat and sodium listed in the first five ingredients on food labels, which means they're main ingredients in that particular item. However, they're not always listed as such, so it's important to check for the following:





a. Salt might be listed as baking powder, booster, celery salt, garlic salt, sodium, meat or yeast extract, onion salt, MSG, rock salt, sea salt, sodium bicarbonate, sodium metabisulphite, sodium nitrate, nitrate or stock cubes.

b. Fat might be listed as beef fat, butter, shortening, coconut, palm oil, copha, cream, dripping, lard, mayonnaise, sour cream, vegetable oils and fats, hydrogenated oils, full-cream milk powder, egg or mono/di/triglycerides.



2 Check serving size (and take into account actual portion size)

When checking nutritional tables, always use the column that states the amount of sugars, fats, etc per serving size – and also try to determine whether the serving size is a practical one. If you think the portion size will be bigger or smaller than the stated serving size for your kids, take this into account when determining



how much sugar, sodium and fat will be contained in a single serving for them.

3 Not all fats are created equal

Kids need fats to grow, but too many saturated fats can negatively impact heart health. Foods with 1g or less of saturated fats per serving are considered low

“Many foods that seem to be healthy actually contain a lot of hidden sugars and sodium.”



Nutrition Facts		
Amount Per Serving		
Calories 85	Calories from fat 4	
% Daily Value		
Total Fat 0g		0%
Saturated Fat 0g		0%
Trans Fat		0%
Cholesterol 0mg		0%
Sodium 2mg		0%
Total Carbohydrate 20g		5%
Protein 0g		
Vitamin A	5%	Vitamin C 15%
Calcium	5%	5%
	Calories:	2,000 2,500
Total Fat	Less than	60g 80g
Sat Fat	Less than	30g 80g
Cholesterol	Less than	210mg 210mg
Sodium	Less than	2,500mg 2,500mg
Total Carbohydrate		300g 380g
Fiber	Sat Fat	30g 30g
Calories per gram: Carbohydrate 5 Protein 5		
Fat 10		

in saturated fat. It's also best to avoid trans fats as much as possible for healthy arteries and better health overall. Avoid foods with hydrogenated oils/fats which are the main source of trans fats in foods.

“Children often gravitate towards sugary or salty foods and it's our job as parents and caregivers to have healthy options available that aren't laden with sugar and sodium, but are still tasty,”



says Mapholi. “Many foods that seem to be healthy actually contain a lot of hidden sugars and sodium. These include fruit juices, sauces, cereals, dried fruit and other snacks specifically designed for children.”

One of the biggest concerns when it comes to children’s diets is the excessive intake of sugary drinks. When it comes to sugar consumption, children aged two to 18 should be limited to 25g per day, which is less than six teaspoons.



In a medical article published by Harvard, Dr Frank Hu, Professor of Nutrition and Epidemiology at the Harvard Chan School of Public Health, wrote: “There is clear evidence that added sugars, especially sugary beverages, contribute to obesity and other metabolic problems.”

According to Mapholi, the high intake of sugary drinks, including fruit juices, cordials and fizzy drinks, is currently a major concern for South African children. “There are many hidden sugars in such drinks and we’re urging parents and caregivers to veer away from these options for hydration. Rather choose water or

rooibos tea, which are healthier options for children.”

Laager’s Rooibos has a tea range designed specifically for children. “Tea4Kidz Rooibos tea is naturally caffeine- and sugar-free, but this doesn’t detract from the taste, as rooibos itself is naturally sweet,” says Candice Sessions, Laager Marketing Manager. Laager Tea4Kidz has a range of flavours, including two with added vitamin C for even more

health benefits. Parents and caregivers can also access a range of healthy recipes, advice and tips via the Joekels website (www.joekels.co.za), @Tea4Kidz on Facebook and @LaagerRooibosTea on Instagram.



Let there be music!

The eAr Academy is revolutionising the way music education is delivered in South Africa by offering a highly scalable solution

The traditional approach to teaching music is often costly, rigidly tied to classical music conventions and can be dogmatic and become dispassionate. Practical constraints such as time for lessons and availability of trained teachers also limit the genres and instruments that most students can explore.

Overly competitive and intimidating to youngsters, the legacy approach has resulted in an unbalanced scenario where many start to learn music during primary school. Several of them stop their musical learning in high school and few ever progress to university-level music institutions, or go on to become professional musicians.

This approach has perpetuated the myth that each of us is either a one-in-a-million virtuosic maestro or simply a passive consumer of music, devoid of creative potential.

By contrast, in many ancient cultures, there was little or no distinction between listeners and performers, as entire families, tribes and

“With its innovative approach, the group aims to provide an affordable and accessible platform for students.”



(Right): Rus Nerwich,
Greg Krupp and
Hein van de Geyn.



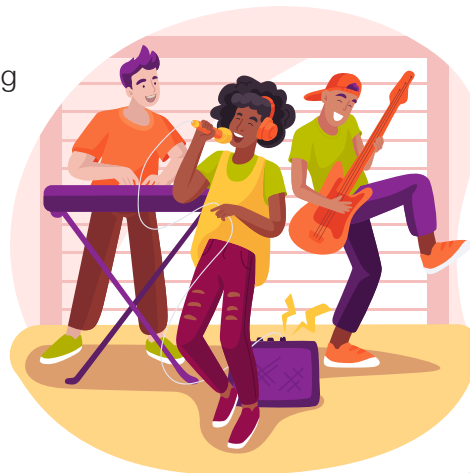
villages would sing, dance and make music together. Musical knowledge and expertise were shared and universal.

The eAr Academy's highly inclusive and accessible, digitally enabled model is challenging archaic legacy approaches to music education, eroding conventional boundaries and showing that musical excellence can be effectively transferred digitally.

"The academy's innovative offering brings together a comprehensive toolset for music education – including tuition, sheet music, inspiration and handy tools – into a single hub that's easily accessible on almost any mobile phone, tablet or laptop, rather than through exclusive

and expensive formal tuition," says the academy's co-founder and celebrated musician Rus Nerwich.

Offering a comprehensive curriculum consisting of carefully sculpted and refined content modules developed in collaboration with leading global music learning institutions, the academy's learning management system



also integrates seamlessly into schools' existing management systems, capacitating teachers and potentially bringing superior musical training – previously only available to a fortunate minority – to all young South Africans.



“This means that, for the first time, schools – as well as those who’re being homeschooled in SA – can afford to offer guitar, electric bass, piano, drums, trumpet and alto saxophone, starting from beginner level,” explains Nerwich.

Exploring a diverse range of genres such as pop, rock, reggae, Latin, jazz, blues and folk, the courses offer a level of depth and personalisation unlike anything else on the market. “We’re confident that after completing all nine levels, our students will be eligible for acceptance at music departments at any university in or outside the country,” he adds.

The courses are organised around seven key facets: tunes, études, exercises, reading, improvisation, hearing and theory.

Nerwich explains that the material’s taught in a non-linear, yet progressively organised open-ended learning environment designed to



stimulate curiosity, passion and playfulness. The facets are integrated and intertwined, presented in an online “playground” with a circular interface that encourages organic, self-guided exploration. The eAr Academy offers genuine educational integrity with a framework based on tried and trusted pedagogy, in which the ear-hand relationship is central.

“Our methodology acknowledges that, much like play, music is best learnt through imitation and repetition,” says Nerwich.

The courses are structured across nine training levels and consist of video tutorials, practice assignments, reading tasks and

improvisation sessions, letting students learn from some of the country’s best music teachers at school or at home in their own space, at their own pace.

“Studies associate involvement in some form of musical education with various unexpected benefits for pupils at both primary and high school levels. Improvements discovered in these studies include social growth, better grades, increased school attendance, more self-confidence and a lasting sense of community,” he notes.

“At the heart of the eAr is our belief that learning music should be playful, fun and accessible to all.”

By democratising high-quality music education, the eAr Academy is heralding a vibrant, new era for SA’s music scene. With its innovative approach, the group aims to provide an affordable and accessible platform for students to explore and express their musical talents and to break down the barriers that have traditionally kept many people from fully realising their musical gifts.



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Myths and truths



Does knowing or applying a specific learning style really help your child learn better? Dalena van der Westhuizen, cognitive development specialist, master brain coach and co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, shares what research studies tell us

Has anyone ever told you “I’m an auditory learner” or “My child’s a visual learner”?

It’s a statement I hear on a regular basis and it’s based on a belief in learning styles. The assumption that students have distinct learning styles and learn best through these channels has influenced the way children are taught to study and teachers are taught to teach for decades –

despite a lack of evidence that such styles even exist.

“Identify your child’s learning style” is a topic that’s especially prevalent now, as we approach the halfway mark of another academic year and parents frantically seek ways to understand their children’s learning needs and help them study more easily. It’s also usually the time of year when “learning style assessments” and endless study method



courses “based on your child’s brain profile” (usually a learning style profile or a personality/temperament profile) pop up everywhere.

And year after year, children from pre-school to varsity age are quick to be labelled with a specific “learning style” and given guidelines on how to study accordingly, supposedly to help them learn more effectively.

Although there are more than 70 different learning style frameworks, here are the most common learning style classifications:

- **Visual learners** – those who learn best by seeing concepts in pictures and diagrams. (So-called



right-brained learners are believed to be among these.)

- **Auditory learners** – those who learn best by hearing/listening. (So-called “**left-brained learners**” are believed to be among these.)

- **Kinesthetic learners** – those who learn best by incorporating movement or hands-on activities.

Why does the notion of learning styles hold such appeal? On the surface, it makes sense that modifying information to suit an individual’s preferred method of receiving and understanding it will improve learning outcomes.

For many parents, students and even educators, the idea that different people have different learning styles feels right and intuitive (and because they’re often unaware of the cognitive brain processes required for the processing of information – and thus for learning to take place – they completely buy into the learning style craze).

It *feels* right and often ticks many of the boxes about what they’re already observing when their child studies. Therefore, it must *be* right. As a parent, I can certainly understand the appeal of what learning styles promote – a way of understanding how your child prefers to study, which would, in theory, make that a lot easier for both of you.

However, here's the problem:

Does knowing or applying your learning style really help you learn better? Science says “no”.

No matter how hard scientists have looked for evidence of the learning style theory, they've never found any. Indeed, an overwhelming (and ever-growing) number of academics and researchers who study this for a living consider learning styles to be one of the biggest myths in education.

Why? Though we each might have an inherent preference for learning in a specific way, it's our ability to process information (ie the cognitive skills/abilities on which we rely) that ultimately determines how successfully we truly digest and comprehend that information.

Cognitive skills are the core skills your brain uses to learn, read, plan, remember, reason, think on your feet and pay attention.



Each of our cognitive skills plays an important role in processing information. Research studies and MRI scanning shows that multiple areas in our brains, and on both sides of it, are simultaneously processing (lighting up) when we work with information.

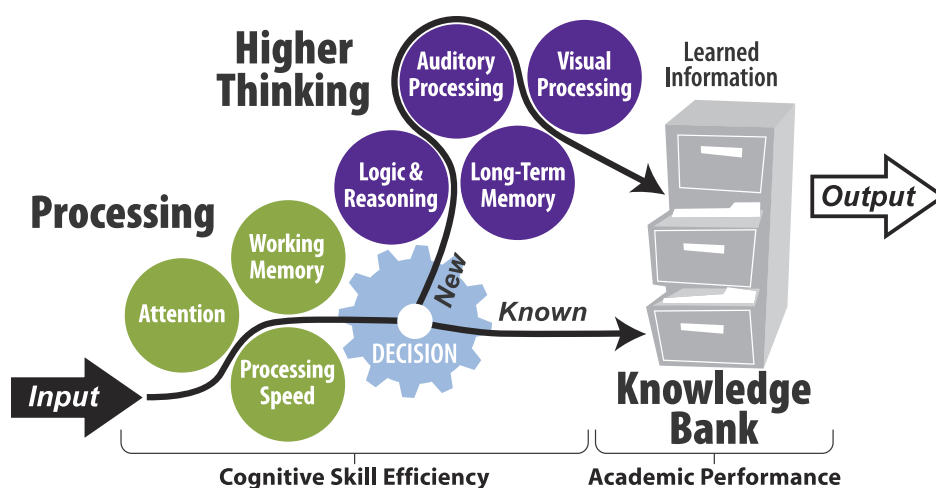
Although a student who has stronger visual processing skills, for instance, might prefer visual study methods to learn, theoretically making them a “visual learner”, the reality is that while studying or working in any way

with information, that student relies on all their cognitive brain functions to work together in order to successfully process, store, recall and apply the information.

This means that if even one of your cognitive skills is weak, no matter what kind of information is coming your way or which preferred learning style or study method you're using, grasping, retaining or using that information is impacted.

While studying according to your preferred learning style might make a difference in the short term, as it feels more natural and in line with your personality/temperament, it does nothing to change or improve the way your brain's able to process the information.

Therefore insight into your individual cognitive profile – before applying any learning style or study method – would yield much better long-term benefits.

COGNITIVE SKILLS AND LEARNING

Lesedi Cultural Village

[Lesedi Cultural Village](#) is located in the heart of the bushveld amid the rocky hills within the Cradle of Humankind, a World Heritage Site. Discover the fascinating cultures and traditions of the people of

Africa, visiting five traditional homesteads inhabited by Zulu, Xhosa, Pedi, Basotho and Ndebele tribes who live according to tribal customs. This venue's unique outdoor atmosphere is complemented

by an authentic African "braai" menu. Visitors are also invited to enjoy the essence of *ubuntu* at the village, where the song, music and warmth of its hospitality add a truly unique touch to your experience.

Saddle up in the Western Cape

[Horse-Riding Cape Town](#) is an equestrian travel and adventure company specialising in horse trails in and around the Western Cape. It offers trails to suit all riders, from novices to advanced equestrians. You can also choose to explore a number of white sandy beaches, while the horses frolic in the waves. The trail durations range from an hour to multiple days and cater for single riders, as well as families and groups. Experienced guides will ensure your comfort.



Pinboard

Fun local events and outdoor activities in your city and nearby places for the whole family



The Oribi Gorge Nature Reserve

[The Oribi Gorge Nature Reserve](#) is a wonderfully scenic area offering excellent hiking opportunities. Oribi Gorge Nature Reserve lies 21km inland of Port Shepstone, only two hours' drive from Durban. The Oribi Gorge area boasts cliffs, forests, spectacular hiking trails and

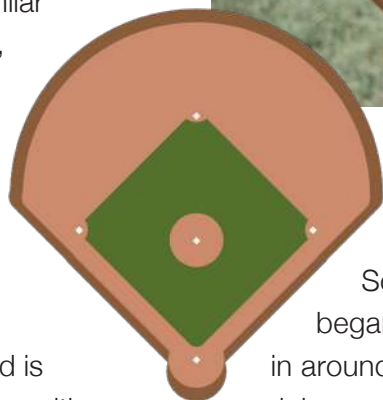
idyllic picnic sites. It's dramatic in its scale and spectacularly beautiful in its variety. Wildlife in the gorge consists of many antelope. Other fun family activities include paintball wars, birding, ziplining, abseiling, white-water rafting and testing your adrenaline limits on the Wild Swing.

Let's play softball!

Softball is an awesome sport that's touched many lives in a positive way. It's a fantastic way for children and adults to stay active and healthy, while also enjoying the camaraderie of a team sport. And, unlike other sports that require extensive training and specialised equipment, softball's accessible to anyone aged eight to 80.

Its rules are very similar to those of baseball, except that it has a smaller field and a larger, softer ball, which the pitcher throws using an underhand motion.

A typical softball field is shaped like a triangle, with one rounded side. The field's divided into an infield and an outfield. Four bases lie inside the infield. The bases are called home plate, first base, second base and third base, and mark the corners of a square area called the diamond. A pitcher's mound rises in the middle of the diamond, with



the outfield lying beyond the infield.

Softball as a sport began in South Africa in around 1946. It started mainly as a women's game, but the first national women's team was only assembled in 1959. The men's game started in 1947, with the teams playing fast-pitch softball. The sport became very popular in the 1950s and 1960s, with the then Transvaal alone having over 250 softball teams.

Softball SA (SSA) is the national governing body for the sport in this country and is responsible for its promotion and development locally. It has 200 clubs across the country, over 10 000 players, over 1 000 000 fans and supporters, and over 120 technical officials.

What makes the sport unique is that it requires players to be adept at multiple skills. Whether it's running, fielding, swinging or throwing, there's a need to be co-ordinated throughout multiple skills and muscle groups.



Softball is more than just a great way for kids, teens and adults to get active – it's a fast-paced, team-building, leadership skill-inducing sport. Even more importantly, it's fun and exciting



Softball welcomes anyone, regardless of their age, gender or athletic ability. Everyone can participate in it and enjoy themselves.

One of the reasons it's so inclusive is that it's a non-contact sport, so there's less risk of injury.



Softball is also a sport that values teamwork and sportsmanship, which makes it a great way to build relationships and find new friends. This is true whether you're playing for a recreational team or a competitive league.

"For all who play the sport, softball's more than just a game – it's a community of players, coaches and fans who share a love for it," says Malcolm Jenner, Chairperson of the KwaZulu-Natal (KZN) Softball Association.

There are several teams involved in the association. "We have a senior league based in eThekweni. We also have a KZN schools league based primarily in Durban. Heading beyond Durban, the University of Zululand joined KZN Softball in the first half of the season. We also have junior clubs made up of homeschooled children based in our Midlands region," says Jenner. "In addition, we have a home for the disabled in Howick which has three teams."

The KZN Softball Association hosted the 2023 Softball SA National Championships at Hoy Park, Durban in March this year. "We're super-proud of the numerous tournaments that KZN Softball's hosted in the past. These championships saw the cream of SA's crop playing with all provinces represented. Not only were national titles up for grabs, but it was a good platform for all our U23 national men and

senior national women players, who travel to the World Cups later this year," says Jenner.

"From improving your health and fitness to building friendships and just having fun, there's no doubt that softball's a great sport for all."

So if you're looking for a fun and exciting sport for your children – or the whole family – why not give softball a try?





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SA HOMESCHOOLING AND BEYOND'S
2023 DRAWING COMPETITION

It's our 2023 Drawing Competition!

This initiative is aimed at encouraging children to express themselves through drawing, inspiring creativity, stimulating the imagination and encouraging artistic skills. There are four age categories, all with the same theme.

Theme: Why I love South Africa

**5-8 years, 9-12 years,
13-17 years and 18-21 years**

Entries must be e-mailed to:
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with "Drawing Competition"
clearly stated in the subject
line along with:

**Your full name
Contact number
Child's name and age
Title of drawing**

The competition will run for two issues, this being the first. Every fortnight we'll post a section of entries from each category on our social media pages. Winners' names will be announced in our last issue of the year, online in November.

**Follow us on
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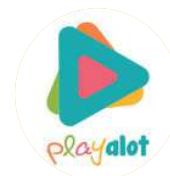
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